Joy Requires Reduced Action Coupling

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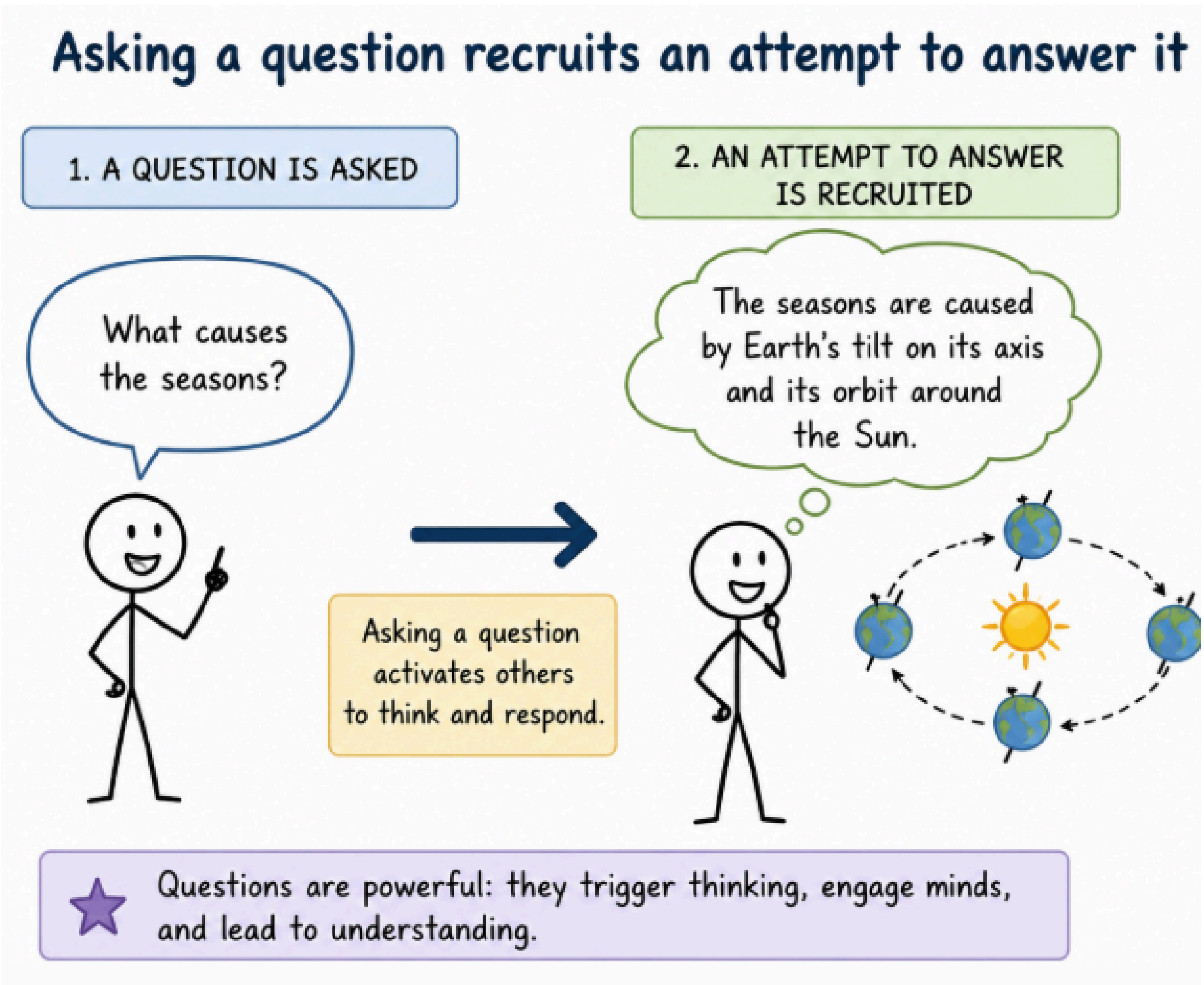
A Regime Theory of Joy

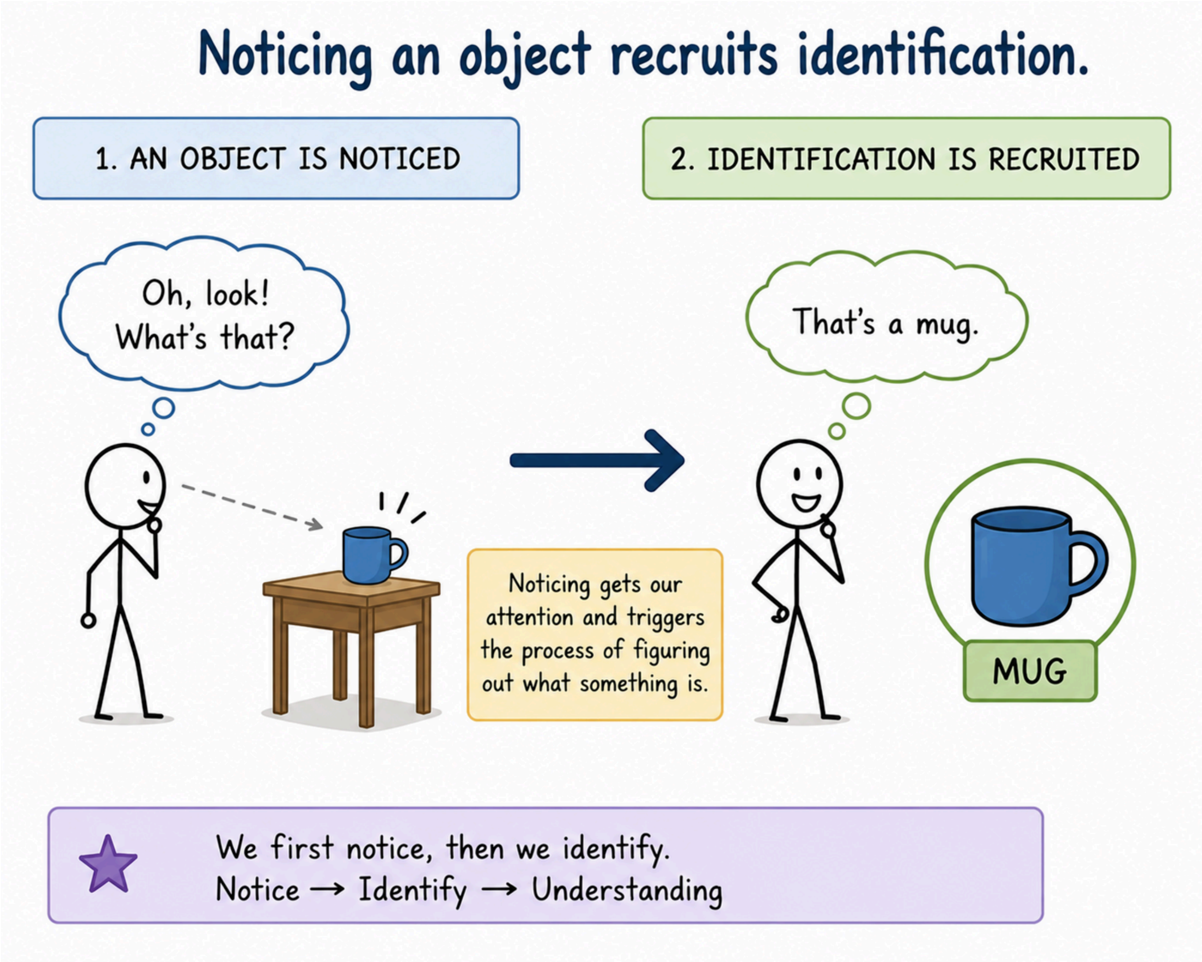
Action coupling

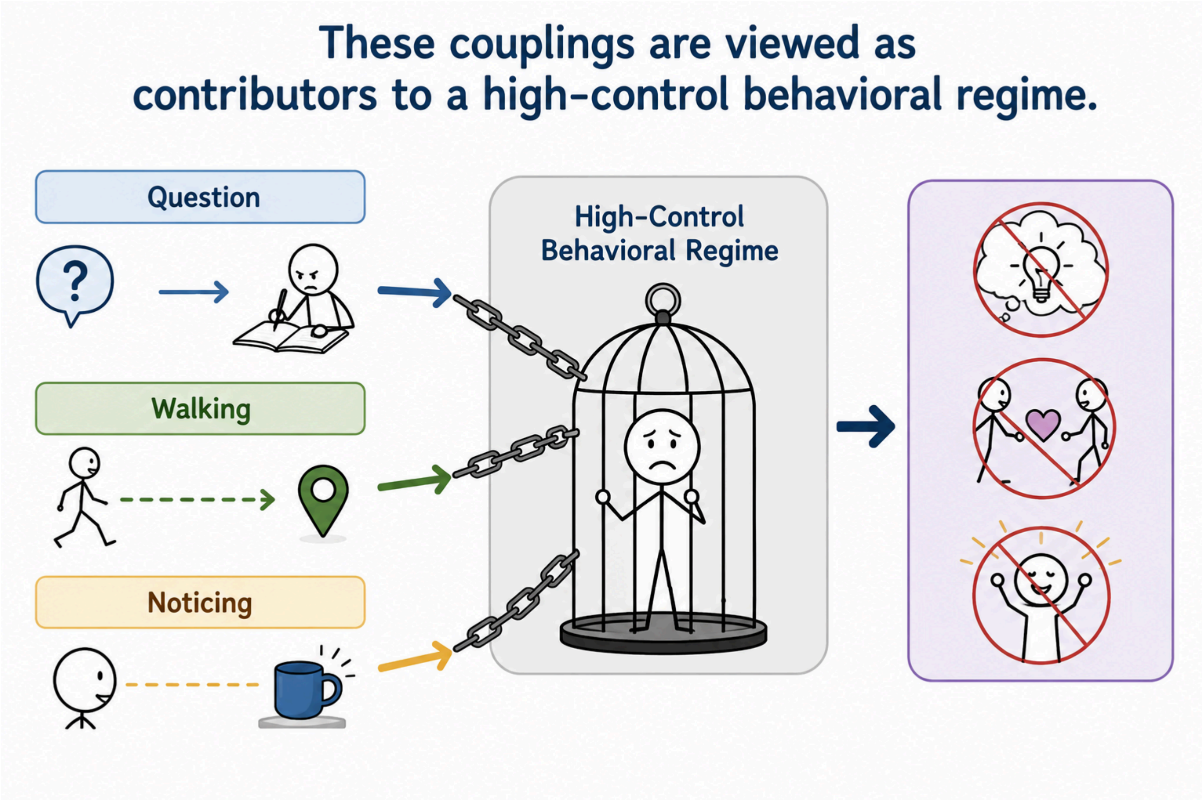
Action coupling refers to the tendency for one action to automatically recruit another.

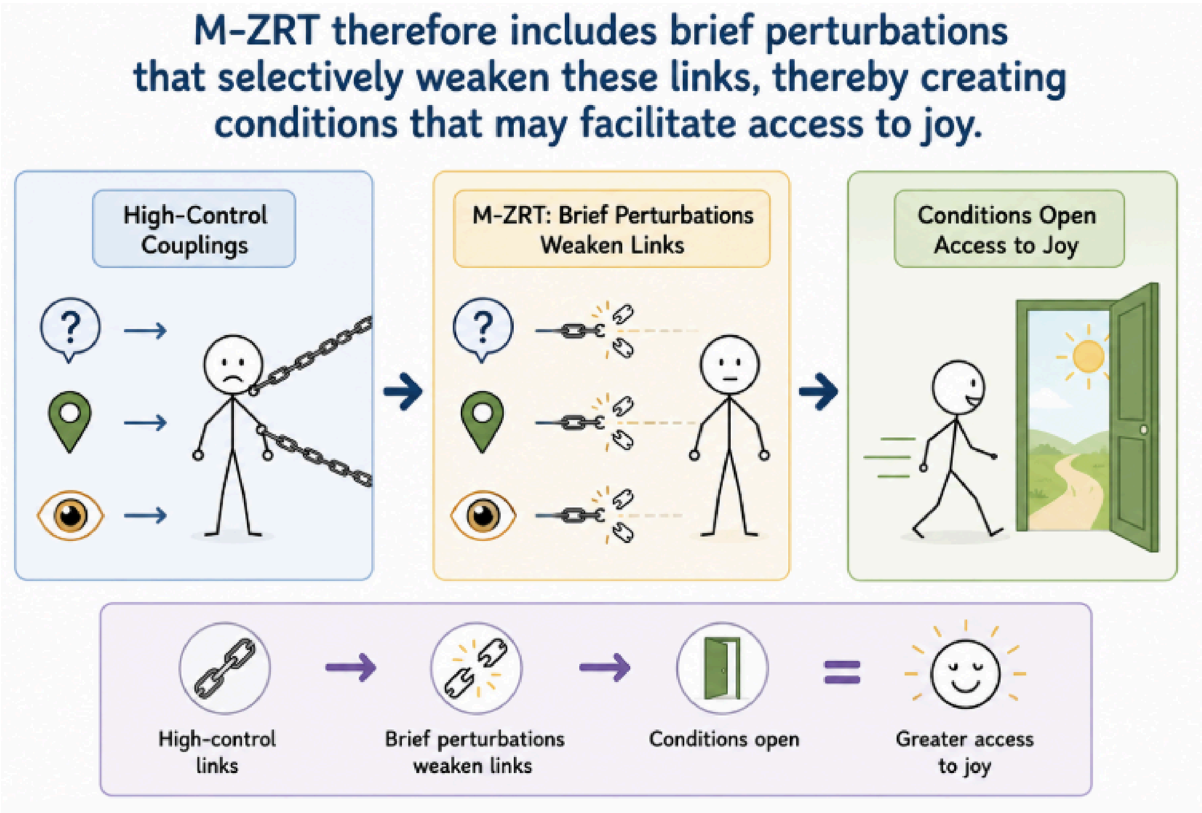
Originality of the framework. To our knowledge, this is the first framework to propose action coupling as the primary variable governing access to joy and to derive a systematic set of behavioral perturbations from that principle.

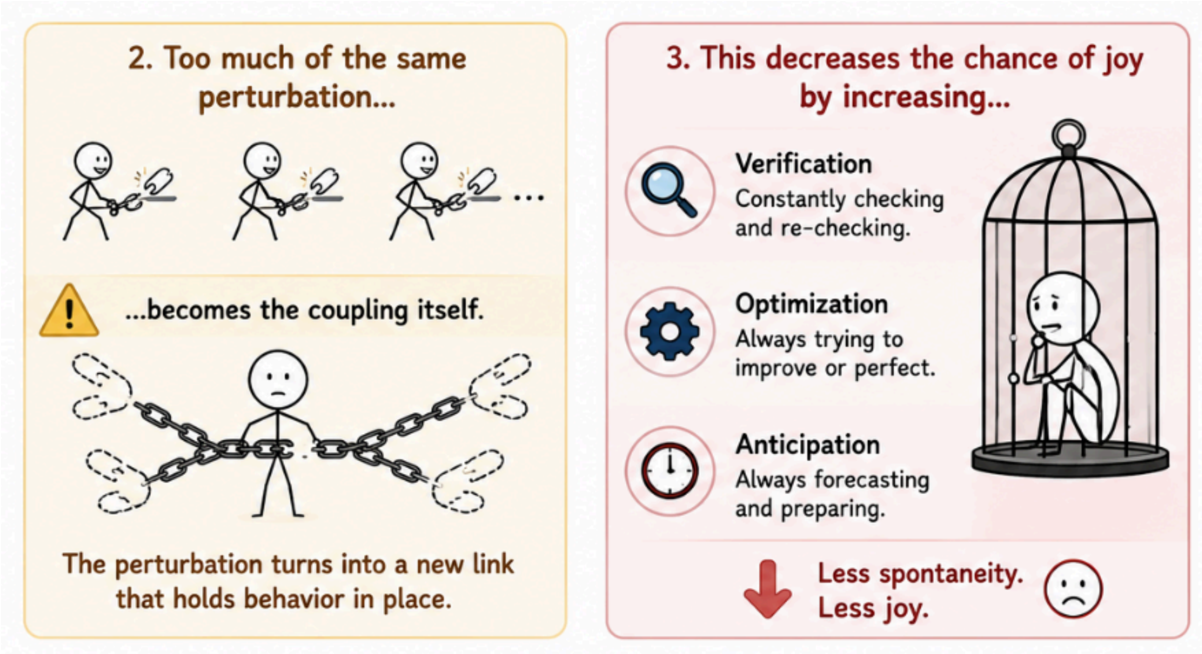


Walking recruits movement toward a destination
1. WALKING IS INITIATED
2. MOVEMENT TOWARD A DESTINATION IS RECRUITED
I want to go to the park.
I'm getting closer to the park!
PARK
Walking activates and guides the body to move forward.
Walking doesn't just happen—it is an active process that recruits movement toward a goal.


Noticing an object recruits identification.
1. AN OBJECT IS NOTICED
2. IDENTIFICATION IS RECRUITED
Oh, look! What's that?
That's a mug.
Noticing gets our attention and triggers the process of figuring out what something is.
MUG
We first notice, then we identify.
Notice → Identify → Understanding


These couplings are viewed as contributors to a high-control behavioral regime.
Question
Walking
Noticing
High-Control Behavioral Regime


M-ZRT therefore includes brief perturbations that selectively weaken these links, thereby creating conditions that may facilitate access to joy.
High-Control Couplings
M-ZRT: Brief Perturbations Weaken Links
Conditions Open Access to Joy
High-control links
Brief perturbations weaken links
Conditions open
Greater access to joy



The goal of the M-ZRT (Minimal Z-Reduction Task, where Z denotes evaluative load) is to reduce the coupling between an action and its expected next action.

Examples include asking a question without attempting to answer it, or making a purposeless detour while walking.

Consider the exercise "Ask a question without answering it." Now imagine that, immediately afterward, you check whether you successfully avoided answering. From an action-policy coupling perspective, this is a failure, because the exercise has become coupled to a verification policy.

Instead of the sequence ending with an unanswered question, it now continues as:

Ask question → avoid answering → verify success.

The verification step becomes the new expected action recruited by the exercise. The behavioral sequence has crystallized into a rule that recruits evaluation whenever the exercise is performed.

The objective is therefore not to "succeed" at leaving questions unanswered, but to prevent the exercise itself from reliably recruiting any particular next action, including checking whether it worked. The exercise should terminate naturally, without requiring evaluation, or completion.

We can now compare two formulations of what appears to be the same exercise and examine how each may influence next action pressure.

1. Ask a question without answering it.

This formulation explicitly instructs the participant to perform two actions: generate a question and avoid answering it. While simple, it can recruit an additional action policy centered on monitoring whether the instruction has been followed. The sequence may become:

Ask a question → avoid answering → check whether I successfully avoided answering.

The participant may repeatedly evaluate whether they are "doing it correctly." Because each evaluation can recruit verification, error detection, and corrective adjustments, it generates additional candidate actions, thereby increasing next action pressure.

2. Small Curiosity

Let a small curiosity arise, such as "Why this color?" or "What if I turned left?" Do not try to answer it.

"Let a curiosity arise" frames the question as something that appears rather than something that must be deliberately produced. Likewise, "Do not *try* to answer it" avoids implying that success must later be verified. As a result, the cognitive sequence is more likely to terminate naturally after the question appears, without recruiting an additional verification policy.

Although both formulations describe a similar observable behavior, they may differ substantially in the amount of next action pressure they generate.

We will now use this reasoning to explore how to reduce next action pressure in an RPG video game by remaining within the game's town and avoiding combat and quests, since both naturally increase next action pressure.

There are three types of exercises: Suspension, Openness, and Salience.

Each targets a different component of **next action pressure**, **reducing it** through a distinct mechanism. This is important because, once next action pressure is sufficiently lowered, the probability of experiencing *joy* increases.

The M-ZRT (Minimal Z-Reduction Task) is the task presented below. It is designed to reduce Z, where Z refers to accumulated next-action pressure.

Joy is a distinct positive affect class. It is not “reward but louder”. It is a kind of affective quietude where it happens without excitement, with altered sensations, in a non-addictive, yet strongly positive way. Radiating chest-pleasure and increased olfaction are core features of joy.

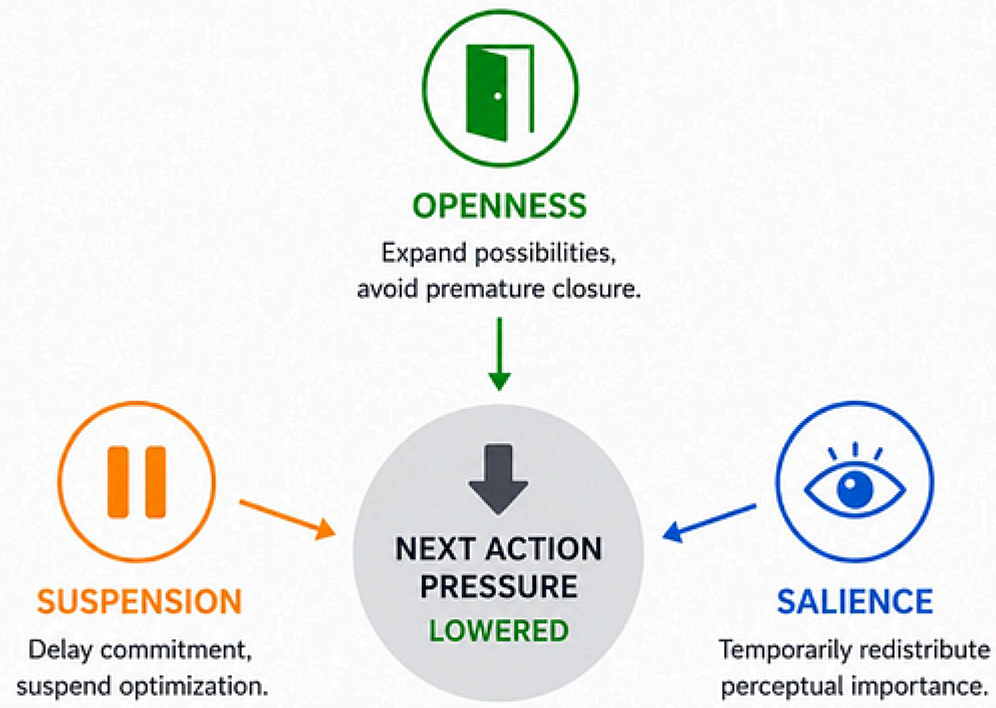


Figure 1. Openness, suspension, and salience exercises all reduce next-action pressure through complementary mechanisms, creating conditions more compatible with the emergence of joy.

These exercises can also be performed in video games. RPGs and enemy-free FPS games are particularly suitable because they contain many of the elements these exercises naturally interact with, such as doors, corridors, intersections, and small objects.

You can also choose one or two exercises and use each monster pack in an RPG as a cue to perform one of them. This way, the exercises become naturally embedded in gameplay and are sufficiently spaced apart, allowing the brain time to process each one before the next occurs.

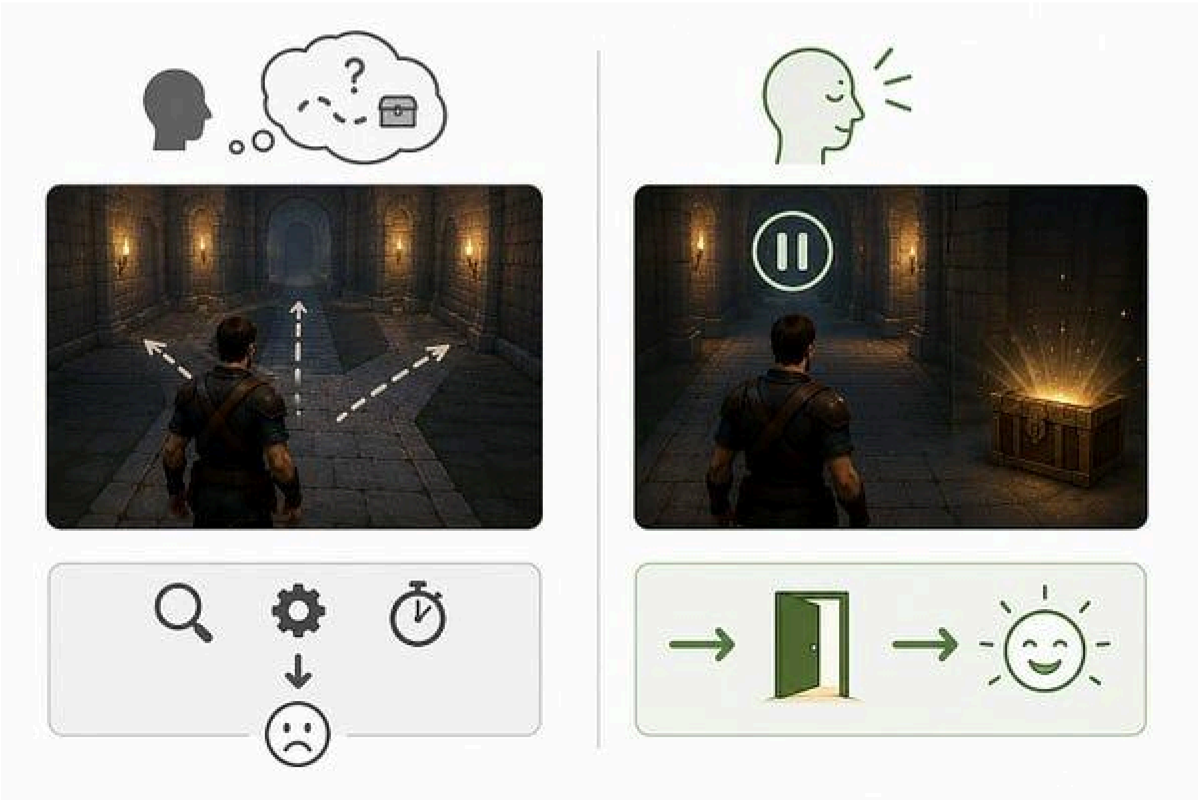
Before the first exercise, note that each session lasts only 2 to 3 minutes, and two sessions per day are sufficient. This limitation is important because the temptation to do more, to extend the session, or to optimize the task by trying to perform it “better” can itself increase next-action pressure.

According to the model, trying to “win” makes entry into joy less likely. It is therefore preferable to perform an imperfect session than to optimize the task, because attempting to maximize success can undermine the very conditions the task is designed to create. A failed session is one in which verification, anticipation, and performance monitoring become the dominant drivers of behavior, thereby increasing next-action pressure.

After each session, you can check for any effect by watching music videos that you already enjoy, especially those that are energetic or emotionally engaging. They tend to make changes in subjective experience more noticeable. Keep in mind that entry is probabilistic, so a given session may produce no noticeable effect. However, once entry has occurred clearly at least once, subsequent re-entry often becomes much easier, and may sometimes occur spontaneously. For this reason, the initial investment of time and commitment is worthwhile.

Exercise: Refraining from imagining *(suspension)*

Description: Refraining from imagining what lies behind a visible obstacle before continuing naturally. One simply refrains from mental simulation.

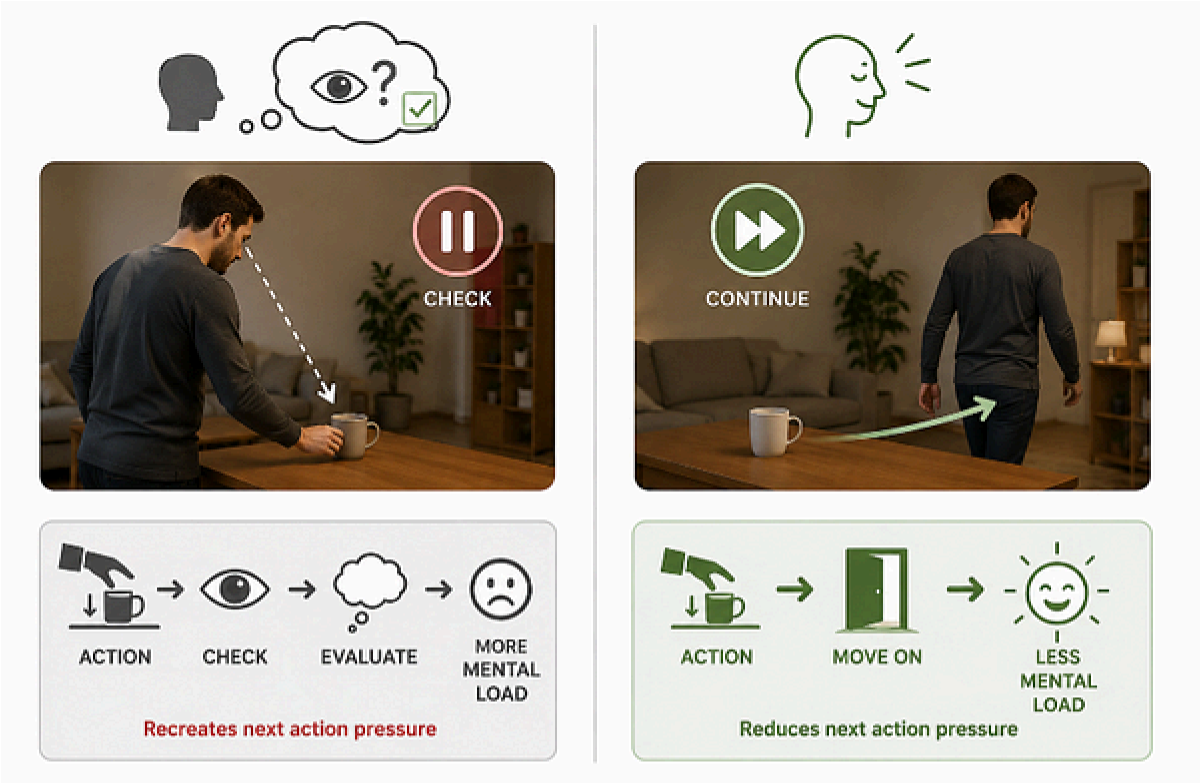


Suspension exercises that involve refraining from prediction or information extraction are relatively straightforward to understand from an action-policy perspective. There is less basis for evaluating an imminent action, thereby reducing next action pressure over the following moments. This reduction is not guaranteed, however.

If the participant begins monitoring whether the exercise is being performed correctly, or treats successful non-prediction as a goal, the exercise itself becomes a new action policy and recreates the same anticipatory control it was intended to weaken.

Exercise: No Checking *(suspension)*

Description: After completing a simple action, do not immediately verify its outcome. For example, after placing an object on a table, resist the brief impulse to check whether it is exactly where intended. Continue directly with the next activity.



From an action-policy perspective, this exercise interrupts the automatic completion cycle in which an action is immediately followed by outcome verification. The action is allowed to remain temporarily unresolved instead of becoming the starting point for another evaluation cycle.

Exercise Alter Your Path *(suspension)*

Description: Because movement is the primary activity in third-person video games, it naturally becomes tightly coupled to navigation and goal pursuit. A chosen direction often immediately recruits a continuous sequence of predictions and movement adjustments. It's possibly the single exercise one may do repetitively: everytime one the brain try to project a plan, you may do a deviation, as show is the video below:

By introducing a short, arbitrary deviation without replacing it with a new objective, the exercise weakens the continuity of action selection and reduces the basis for evaluating the immediately upcoming sequence of actions, thereby reducing next action pressure over the following moments.

Exercise: Abort an Action (suspension)

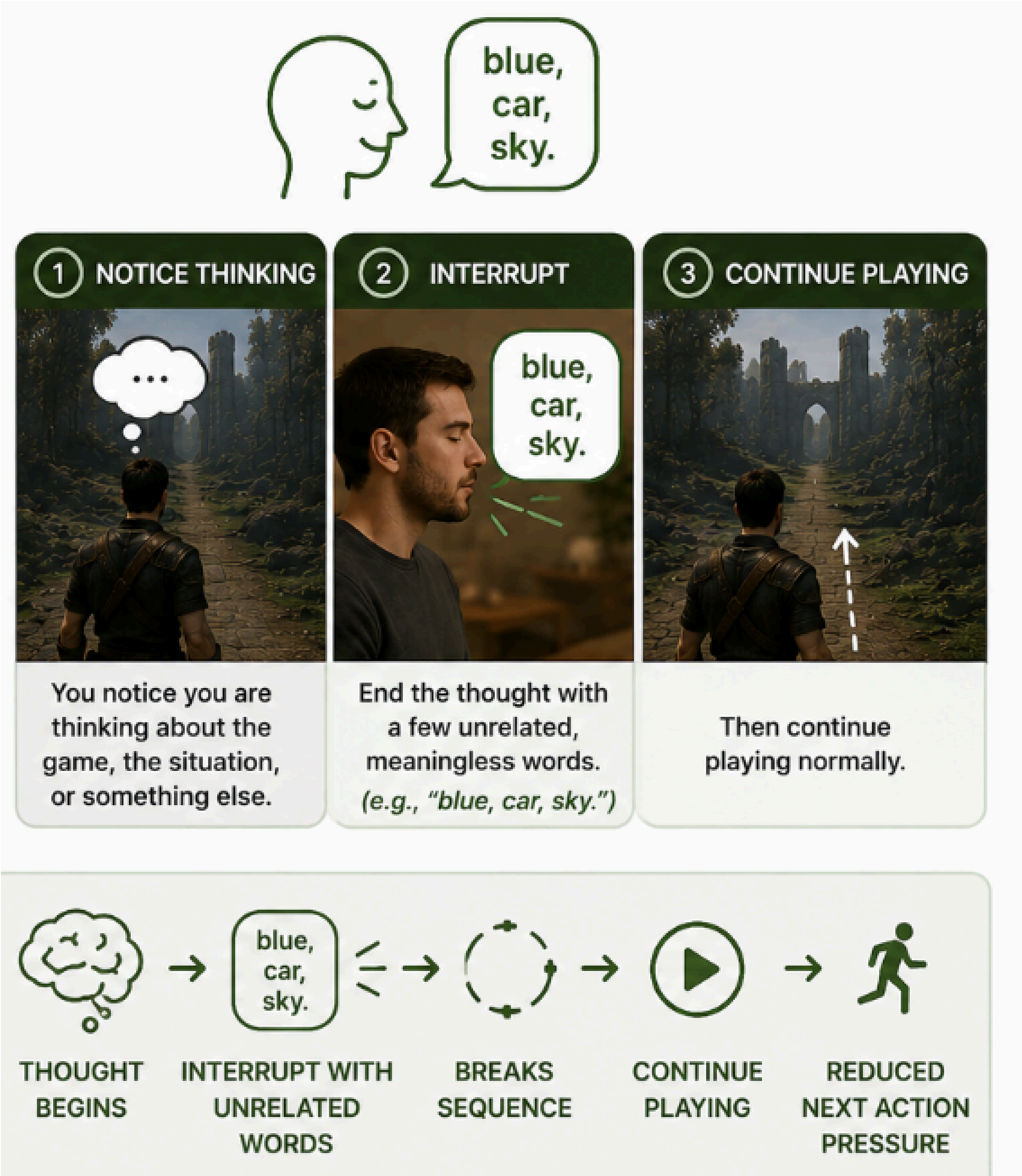
Description: For example, begin reaching for an object, start opening a menu, move toward a doorway, or begin clicking a button, then briefly stop and continue **with something else**. The interruption should be brief and effortless, after which normal activity resumes.

This exercise can be viewed as the real-world equivalent of **Alter Your Path**. Just as a brief deviation while walking interrupts a developing movement policy in a video game, aborting a simple everyday action interrupts an emerging action policy in daily life. It is particularly practical because opportunities arise naturally throughout the day and require no specific environment or preparation.It can also be used to abort an intention, including the intention to perform an exercise.

By interrupting an action before it reaches completion, the exercise weakens the automatic continuity between intention and execution. The developing action policy is allowed to dissolve rather than being carried through to its expected endpoint. Because the interruption is brief and not replaced by another structured objective, next action pressure is reduced over the following moments.

Exercise: Interrupt the Thought (suspension)

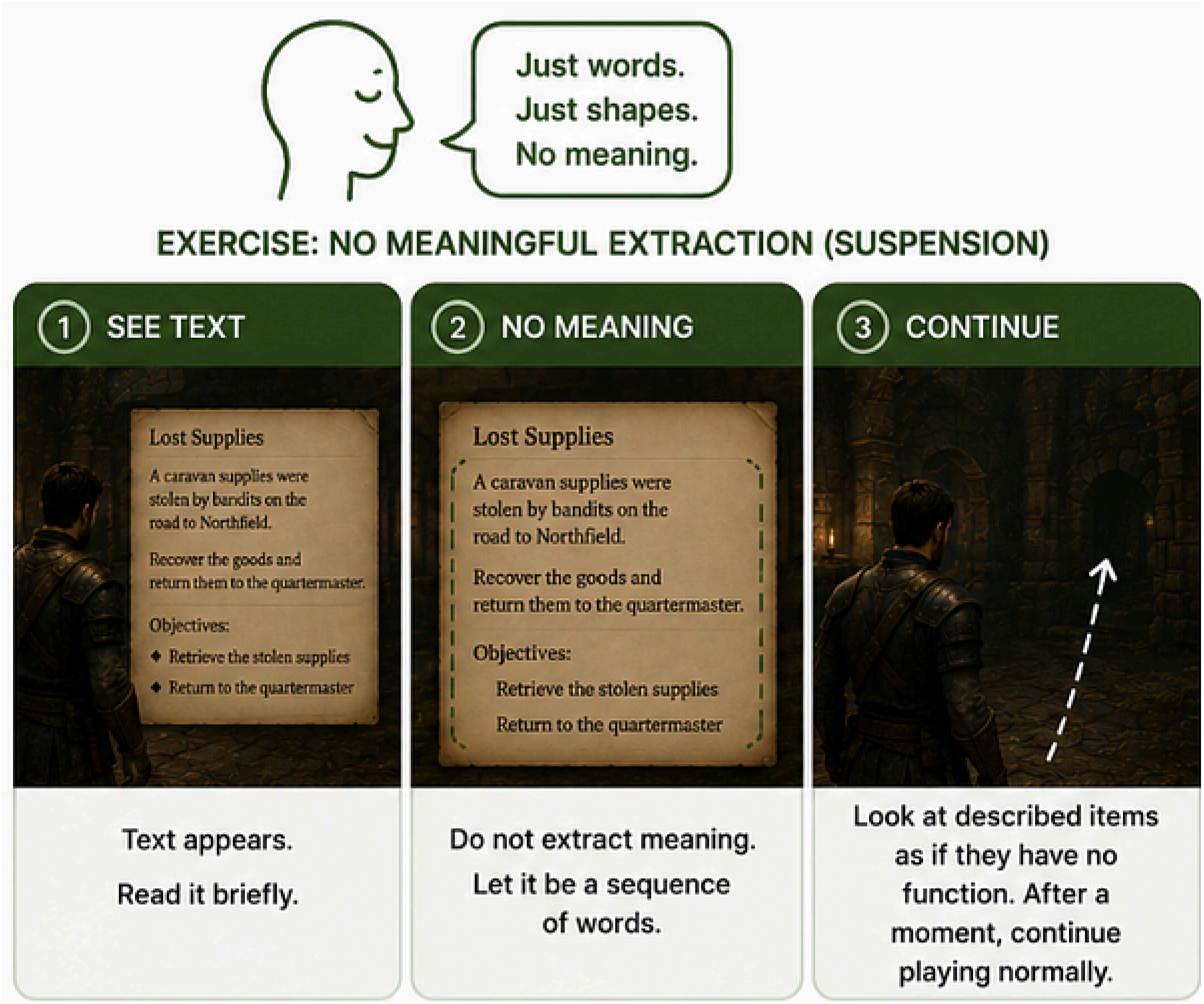
Because internal thought is itself a major source of planning, optimization, and action selection, mental activity naturally becomes organized into sequences that predict and prepare future actions. Whenever you notice yourself thinking about the game, the current situation, the exercise, or anything else, briefly end the thought with a few unrelated, meaningless words, for example, “blue, car, sky.” Then continue playing normally



By introducing a brief, unrelated interruption into an otherwise coherent mental sequence, the exercise prevents the developing thought from becoming a stable predictor of future actions. The interruption is not intended to suppress thinking, but simply to interrupt its continuity before it crystallizes into a sustained action policy, thereby reducing next action pressure over the following moments.

Exercise: No Meaningful Extraction *(suspension)*

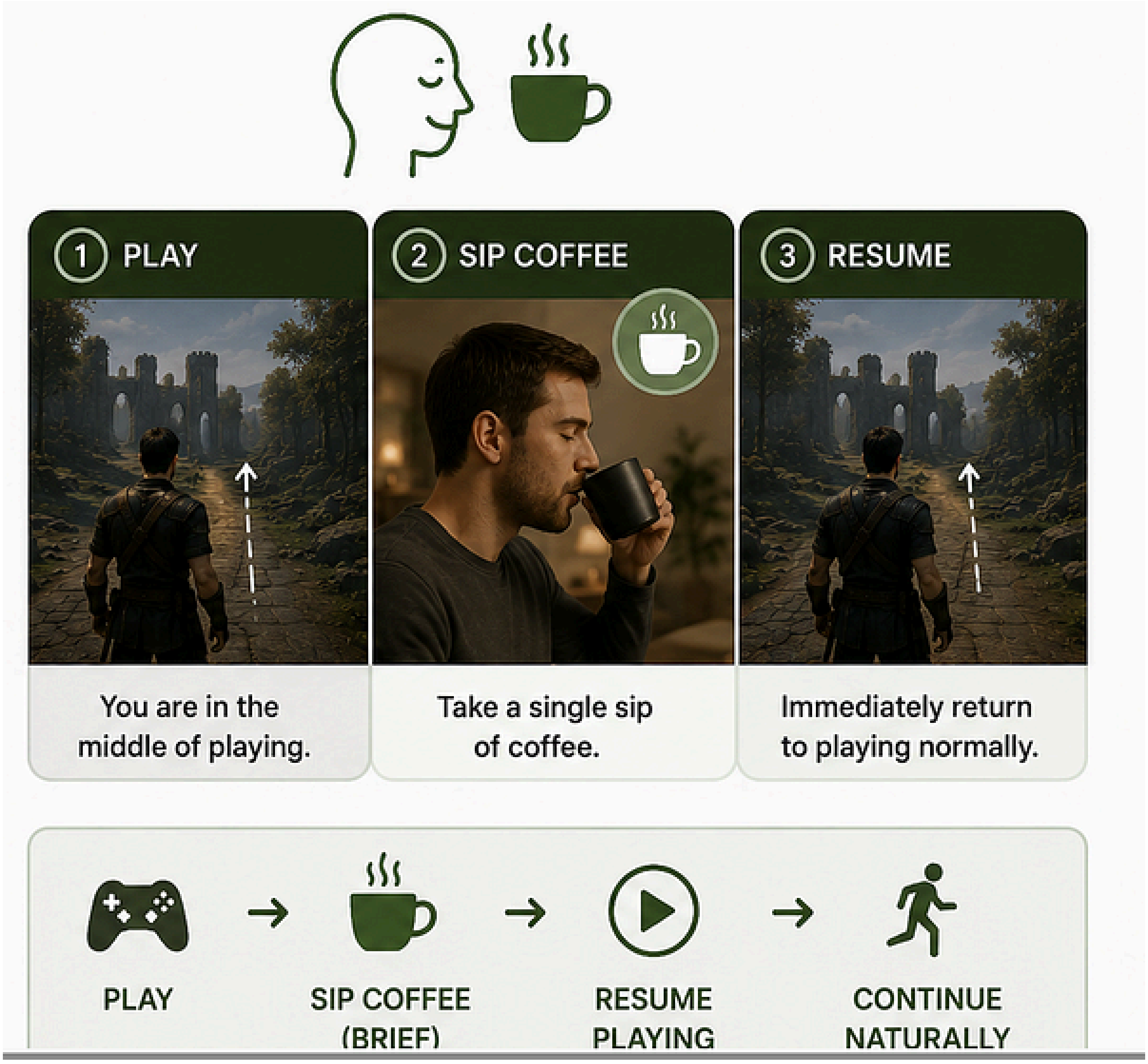
Because text naturally recruits interpretation, categorization, and decision-making, reading often becomes immediately coupled to information extraction and future action selection. Whenever text appears, briefly read it without trying to extract its meaning. Let it remain as a sequence of words rather than information that must be understood. Likewise, briefly look at the objects being described as if they had no predefined function or practical significance. After a moment, continue playing normally.



By temporarily interrupting the automatic transformation of perception into usable information, the exercise weakens the coupling between visual input and action selection. Words remain visual patterns and objects remain perceptual entities rather than immediate sources of goals or decisions. This reduces the basis for evaluating upcoming actions, thereby reducing next action pressure over the following moments.

Exercise: Interruption with a Sip of Coffee *(suspension)*

Description: Because action sequences naturally become continuous during gameplay, introducing a brief interruption can weaken the developing action policy. A single sip of coffee provides a convenient interruption because it is mildly salient without being highly compelling. Unlike highly rewarding or biologically essential stimuli such as sugary drinks or water, coffee generally does not create a strong immediate drive to continue consuming it.

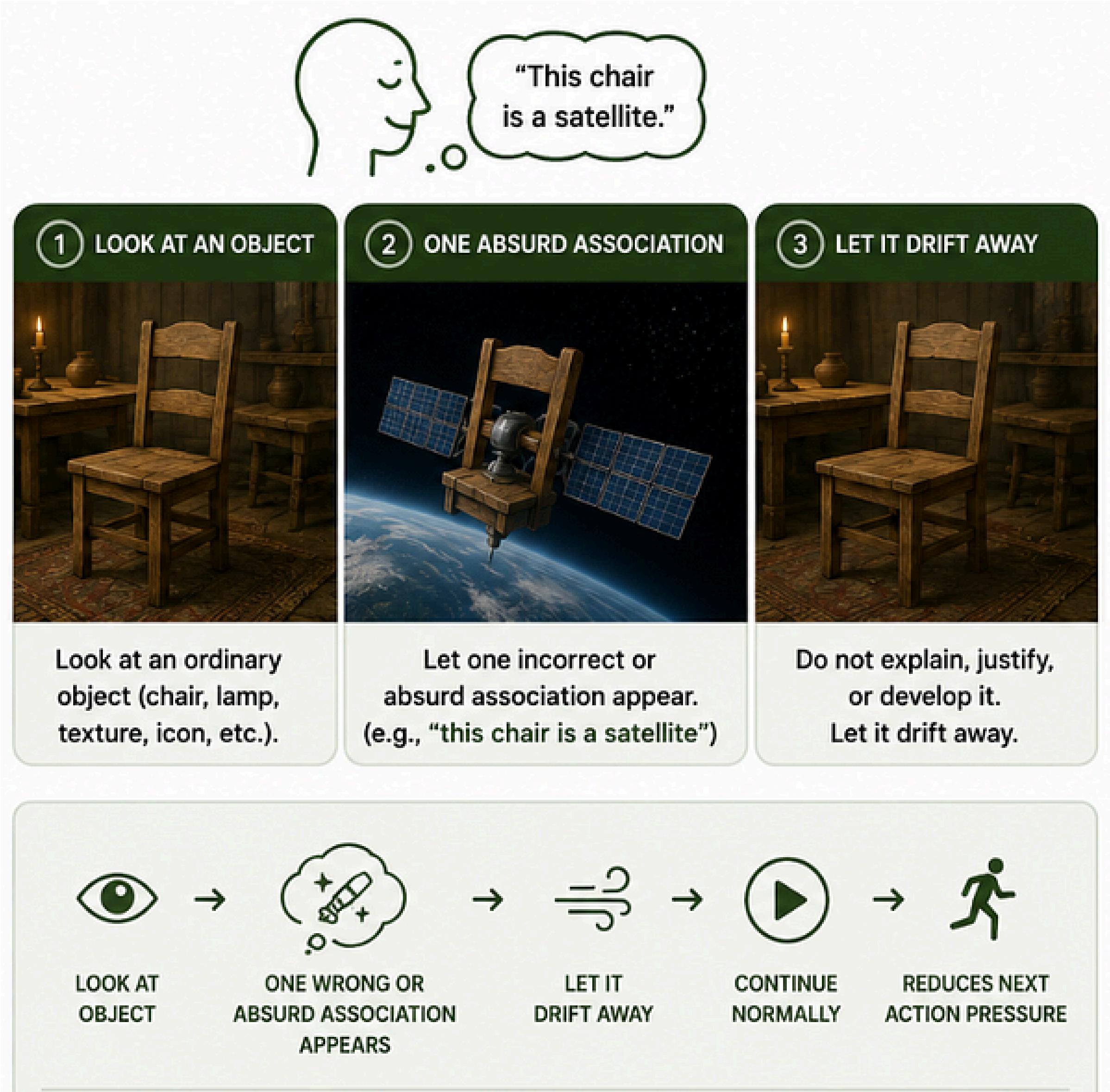


This makes it less likely that the interruption itself becomes a new goal or recruits an extended consumption sequence. During play, take a single sip of coffee, then immediately resume playing normally.

By briefly interrupting the ongoing action with a short, self-limiting event, the exercise disrupts the continuity of action selection without replacing it with another structured activity.

Exercise: Temporary Misclassification *(openness)*

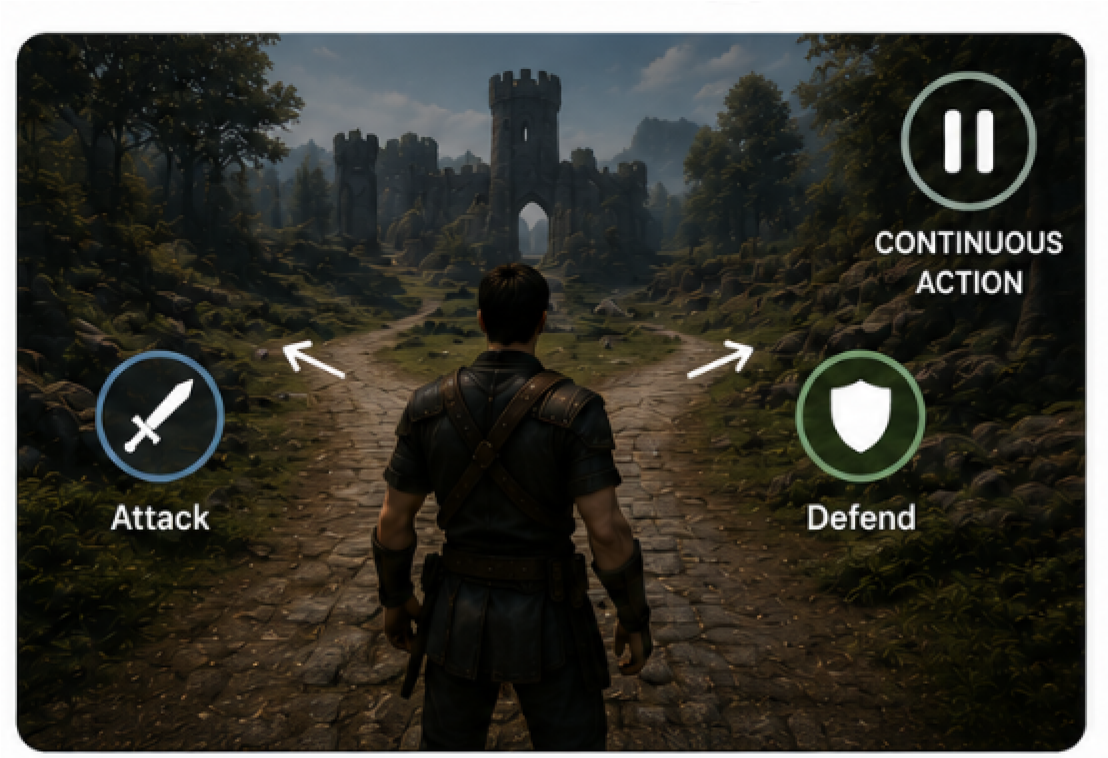
Description: Because perception naturally organizes objects into stable categories, recognition is rapidly coupled to learned identity and expected function. Briefly perceive an ordinary object as belonging to the wrong category. A door becomes furniture, a mug becomes a tool, a tree becomes decoration. Do not attempt to justify the new category or make it internally consistent. After a few seconds, let the object return to its ordinary identity without checking whether the reinterpretation was convincing.



By temporarily disrupting the automatic assignment of category membership, the exercise weakens the coupling between perception and its default conceptual organization. Because the alternative category is neither defended nor developed, it quickly dissolves instead of becoming a new belief or mental model, preserving openness and reducing next action pressure over the following moments.

Exercise: Parallel Action Policies *(openness)*

Description: Because perception and decision-making naturally converge toward selecting a single best action, alternative possibilities are usually discarded as soon as one option becomes dominant. Briefly allow two possible actions to remain equally available before continuing with either one. Simply allow both possibilities to coexist for a moment, then continue naturally with either one.



By temporarily maintaining multiple action policies without immediately resolving the competition between them, the exercise weakens the automatic pressure to optimize and commit as quickly as possible. This preserves openness in action selection and reduces next action pressure over the following moments.

Exercise: One Impossible Rule (openness)

Description: Because familiar scenes are automatically interpreted according to stable physical and conceptual rules, perception rapidly converges on a single coherent model of the environment. Briefly look at a familiar scene and apply one impossible rule. For example, *“shadows are heavier than objects,” “corners remember people,”* or *“windows breathe.”* Do not explain, justify, or test the rule. Let it remain briefly present, then stop immediately and continue playing normally.

By temporarily introducing an impossible rule without attempting to make it coherent or internally consistent, the exercise interrupts the automatic stabilization of the world’s predictive structure. The goal is not to construct an alternative reality, but to momentarily loosen the coupling between perception and its habitual explanatory framework. Because the rule is abandoned before it develops into a narrative or model, it simply dissolves, preserving openness and reducing next action pressure over the following moment

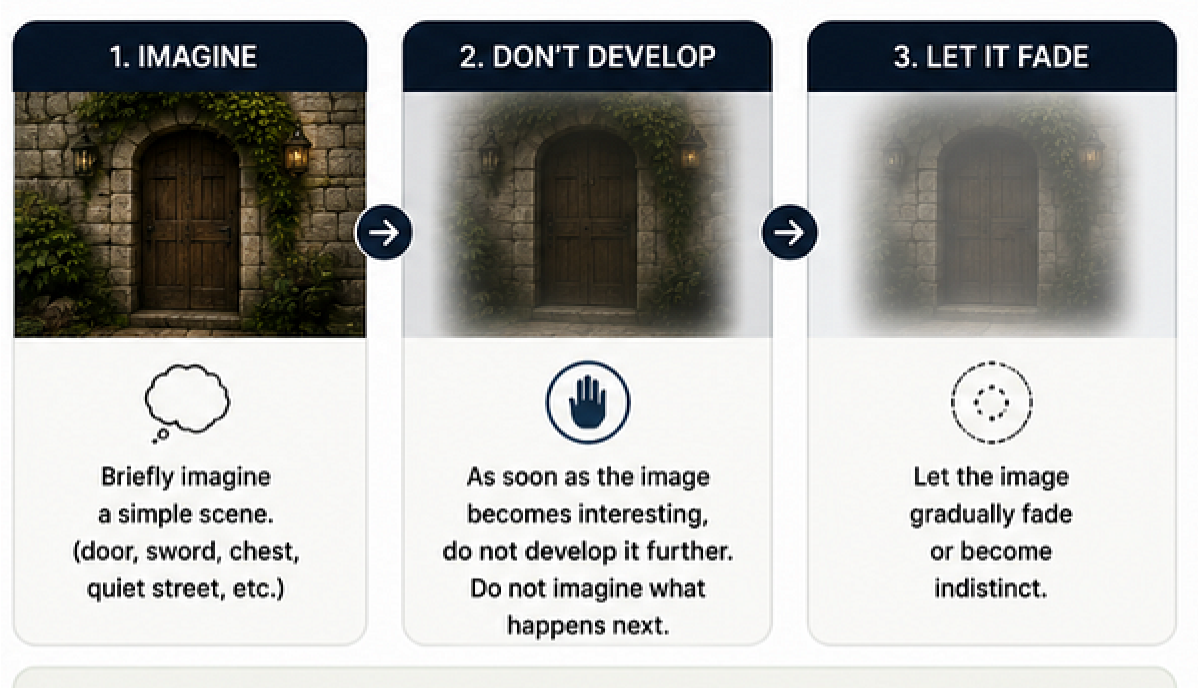
Exercise: Undecided Utility (openness)

Description: Because familiar objects are automatically interpreted in terms of what they are for, perception rapidly converges on a single functional interpretation. Briefly notice any object without deciding whether it is useful or not. Do not classify it as helpful, irrelevant, valuable, or unimportant. Let the object remain temporarily free of a definite role, then continue normally.

By suspending the automatic assignment of utility, the exercise weakens the tendency to stabilize perception around a single interpretation. The object is allowed to remain conceptually open rather than immediately becoming something to use, ignore, or evaluate. This preserves openness by reducing premature conceptual closure and lowers next action pressure over the following moments.

Exercise: Let it Fade *(opennes)*

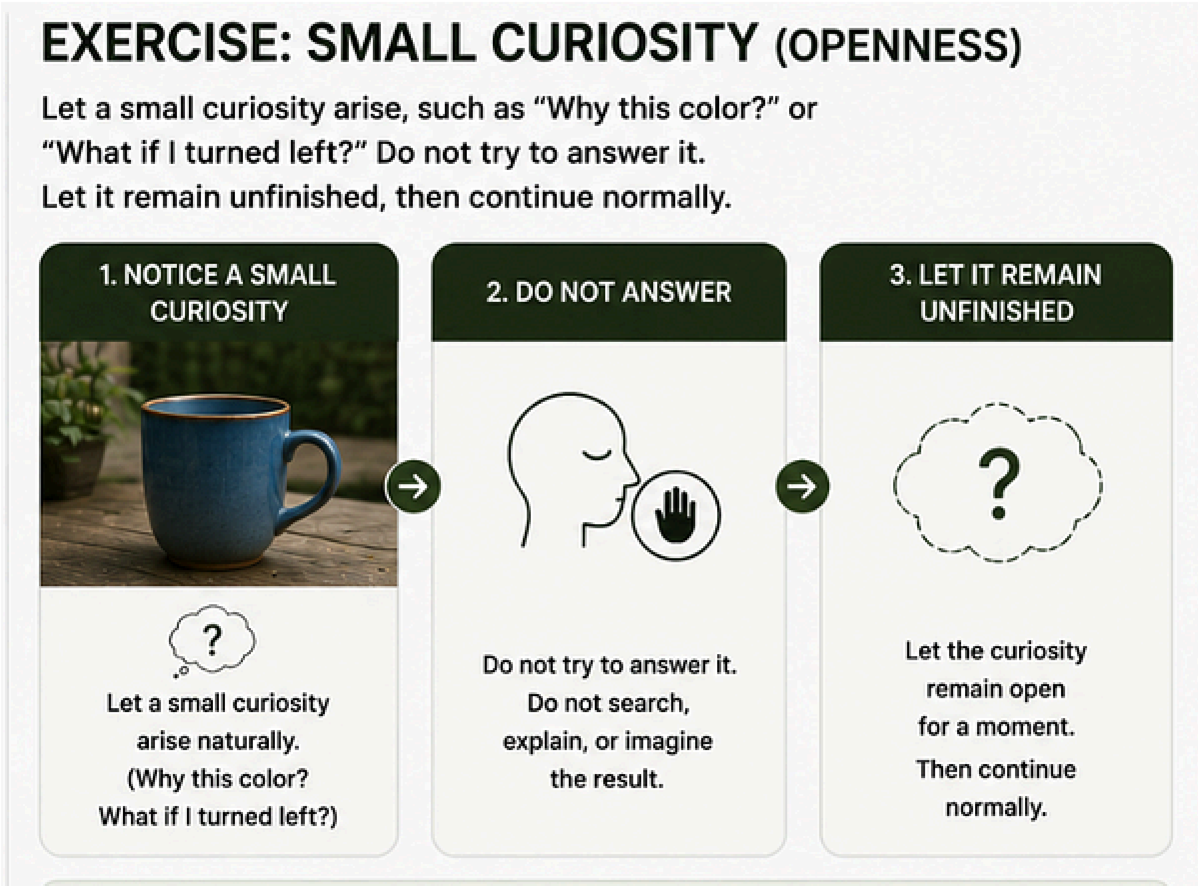
Description: Because mental imagery naturally recruits curiosity, prediction, and elaboration, even a simple imagined scene can rapidly develop into a sequence of expectations and future actions. Briefly imagine a simple scene, such as a door, a sword, a treasure chest, or a quiet street. As soon as the image begins to feel interesting, do not develop it further. Instead, allow the image to gradually fade, blur, or become indistinct. Then continue playing normally.



By interrupting the spontaneous elaboration of a mental image before it develops into an exploratory sequence, the exercise prevents imagination from becoming the starting point of a stable action policy. Because the developing scene is abandoned before reaching resolution, next action pressure is reduced over the following moments.

Exercise: Small Curiosity (openness)

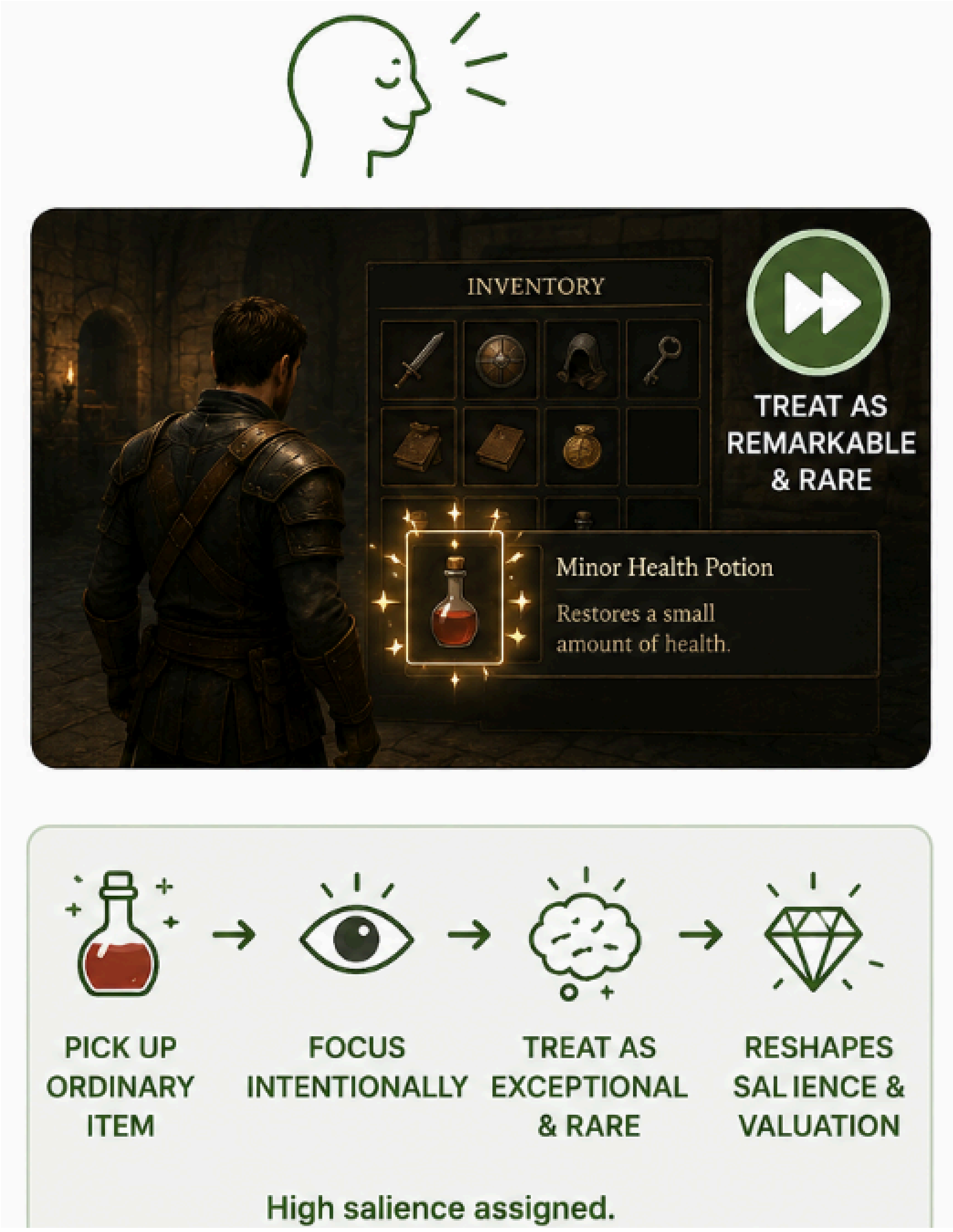
Description: Because questions naturally recruit explanation, prediction, and problem solving, they often develop into extended internal dialogues that guide future actions. Instead of asking a large or important question, briefly allow a small curiosity to arise, such as *“Why this color?”*, *“What if I turned left?”*, or *“Why this sound?”* Do not try to answer it. Let it remain unfinished for a moment, then continue playing normally.



The question functions as a brief opening rather than a problem that requires resolution. This reduces the tendency to search for profound or important questions, encourages short and ordinary curiosities, and lowers the likelihood of developing a prolonged internal dialogue. As a result, openness is preserved and next action pressure is reduced over the following moments.

Exercise: Redistribute Salience *(salience)*

Rare items automatically recruit attention, while ordinary ones are rapidly ignored. This exercise deliberately redistributes perceptual salience rather than following the game’s default value hierarchy. Pick up a completely ordinary item, such as a low-level potion, and briefly treat it as if it were the most rare object in the inventory.



Alternatively, treat it as though the fate of the human civilization depended on it. Do not explain why or build a story around it. Then immediately abandon the idea and let the object return to complete ordinariness. Continue normally.

By temporarily increasing the salience of an otherwise insignificant object without changing its actual function, the exercise weakens the automatic coupling between objective value and perceptual importance. This broadens the distribution of attention and reduces the dominance of naturally goal-relevant stimuli, thereby reducing next action pressure over the following moments.

Exercise: Functional to Incidental *(salience)*

Description: During an activity, briefly look at something that does not help the activity. Because useful objects naturally recruit attention toward the features that guide action, perception rapidly becomes organized around function. For example, while interacting with a useful object, briefly shift attention to one of its incidental features, such as its color, texture, shape, reflection, or a small visual detail, rather than its practical use.

By temporarily redirecting attention from functionally relevant information to perceptually incidental features, the exercise weakens the automatic coupling between salience and utility. The object remains available for action, but its non-functional properties briefly become equally worthy of attention. This broadens the distribution of perceptual salience and reduces the dominance of immediately goal-relevant information, thereby reducing next action pressure over the following moments.

Exercise: Guardian of the Phenomenon *(salience)*

Description: Because moving objects are automatically interpreted in terms of their purpose, destination, or usefulness, attention rapidly becomes organized around prediction and function. Briefly observe something moving. Do not think about what it is for or where it is going. Instead, attend only to the extraordinary fact that a physical object is moving through space, as though witnessing the phenomenon for the first time in your life. After a few seconds, continue normally.

By shifting attention from function and prediction to the raw perceptual event itself, the exercise weakens the automatic coupling between movement and action relevance. The moving object temporarily becomes a perceptual phenomenon rather than a goal, tool, or predictor of future events. This redistributes salience away from utility and toward the experience of perception itself, reducing next action pressure over the following moments.

A simple way to use these exercises is to treat **Alter Your Path** and **Interrupt the Thought** as the default pair. These two exercises target the two main sources of planning in most RPGs: movement through the environment and internal thought. Because both action policies are continuously recruited during play, these exercises can be performed repeatedly throughout a session. You may then add **one openness exercise** and **one salience exercise**, performed much more sparingly.

Another possible approach is to select only **one additional exercise** for the entire session, alongside the default **Alter Your Path** and/or **Interrupt the Thought**. Each time you encounter a new pack of enemies, perform that same exercise once, then continue playing normally. This provides regular but infrequent perturbations without requiring continuous monitoring or exercise selection.

Reference:

Morin, F. (2026). A Regime Theory of Joy: The Ease Regime as a Permissive Control Configuration. *SSRN,*http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6711318
https://florianmorin.com/papers/regime-of-joy/